AFC Bournemouth Scouting Report - Summer 2025

Introduction

Under head coach Andoni Iraola, AFC Bournemouth has undergone a tactical evolution that emphasizes verticality, intensity, and modern pressing principles. Inspired by the aggressive, high-octane systems seen across Europe, Iraola implements a philosophy that hinges on quick transitions, compact pressing structures, and high defensive lines. Bournemouth now favors a style of play that not only demands technical sharpness but also physical discipline and tactical flexibility across all positions.

As the 2024–25 season nears its end, Bournemouth faces a crucial summer transfer window that will likely shape their long-term trajectory. Several players, including loanees and veterans such as Kepa Arrizabalaga, are expected to leave. Additionally, rising stars like Dean Huijsen may attract external interest, especially given rumors of a release clause. These potential departures, coupled with tactical gaps observed throughout the campaign, highlight a need for reinforcements at goalkeeper, center-back, and right-back. Bournemouth's current roster lacks depth in these positions, and replacements must not only meet physical and technical standards but also fit into Iraola's system-driven model.

This scouting report aims to support Bournemouth's summer recruitment efforts through data-driven analysis and visual insights. By leveraging detailed statistical data from FBref and Transfermarkt across the top five European leagues and the UEFA Champions League, we have compiled a shortlist of players who align tactically and statistically with the club's needs. The process begins with defining tactical requirements for each position under Iraola's system, followed by rigorous data collection, normalization, and advanced filtering techniques.

Key performance metrics such as expected goals allowed (xGA), progressive passing, interceptions, and sweeping actions were extracted, adjusted for league difficulty, and standardized across competitions. From this pool, statistical clustering techniques like k-means were applied to identify similar player profiles based on their playing style and output. In addition to raw performance, contextual attributes such as age, market value, and positional role were integrated to further narrow down our shortlist.

The ultimate goal of this report is to identify realistic and data-validated transfer targets that would thrive within Bournemouth's tactical identity. Throughout the report, we present detailed visualizations, radar comparisons, and position-specific evaluations to support each recommendation.

1 Data Computation and Preprocessing

The foundation of this scouting analysis lies in the rigorous acquisition and preprocessing of football data, primarily sourced from FBref.com. Our objective was to identify players—goalkeepers, center backs, and full-backs—who fit AFC Bournemouth's tactical system under manager Andoni Iraola. In order to fairly and objectively compare players from various leagues and teams, we implemented a comprehensive pipeline to clean, standardize, and process the raw data prior to visualization and clustering.

Data Sources and Collection

We began by identifying FBref as our primary data source due to its extensive publicly available statistics across top European leagues, including the English Premier League, Bundesliga, La Liga, Serie A, Ligue 1, and the EFL Championship. For each player position group, we collected position-specific datasets such as *Advanced Goalkeeping*, *Defensive Actions*, *Passing*, *Standard Stats*, *Possession*, and *Miscellaneous Stats*. These CSV files were manually downloaded and stored in structured folders according to league and stat type. In total, we compiled data from seven different statistical files per league across six leagues, along with AFC Bournemouth's team-specific stats.

Cleaning and Preprocessing

The next step involved a thorough data cleaning process using `R` and the `tidyverse` package. We removed unnamed or duplicate columns, handled missing values by replacing them with the column mean, and eliminated rows with insufficient or corrupt data. To ensure comparability, especially for team-level data, we normalized performance metrics to a per-90-minute basis wherever appropriate. This was crucial for analyzing players from teams with unequal game time or tactical usage.

To simulate individual contributions when only team stats were available, particularly in center back and goalkeeper datasets, we estimated positional responsibilities. For example, we assumed two starting center backs per team to estimate per-player defensive stats such as tackles won and aerial duels. This approximation enabled us to extract meaningful player-level insights from team-based data.

Standardization and League Weighting

One of the key steps in our data pipeline was the standardization of statistics via z-score normalization. This process ensured that all performance metrics were on the same scale, making it easier to apply machine learning techniques such as clustering. The z-score transformation subtracts the mean and divides by the standard deviation for each metric, effectively centering the data and eliminating unit-based biases.

In addition to z-score normalization, we applied weighted adjustments to account for league difficulty. Players from leagues such as the Premier League (1.0), Bundesliga (0.9), La Liga (0.9), Serie A (0.9), and Ligue 1 (0.9) retained most of their statistical weight. However, Championship players received a reduced weight of 0.75 to reflect the relative difficulty and competition level of the league. These weights were multiplied directly with the relevant metrics such as tackles won, progressive passes, and sweeper actions.

Feature Selection and Clustering

To group players based on similar traits and performance profiles, we implemented k-means clustering on the standardized datasets. The optimal number of clusters was determined using the elbow method. Features were selected specifically for each position:

- For **goalkeepers**, we selected: *Expected PSxG+/-*, *Sweeper OPA per 90*, *Average Distance of Defensive Actions*, *Launch Completion %*, and *Save %*.
- For **center backs**, we used: *Tackles Won per 90*, *Interceptions*, *Aerial Duels Won %*, *Tackle Success %*, and *Progressive Passes*.
- For **full-backs**, we added: *Progressive Carries* and *Carries into Final Third*, reflecting the need for offensive progression and width in Iraola's system.

After clustering, we identified which groups of players most closely matched Bournemouth's current squad profile (e.g., Kepa or Dean Huijsen) and used those clusters to recommend similar or better-performing alternatives.

Final Output and Visualization

Once processed, the data was exported to Excel and Power BI for visualization. These tools allowed us to create scatter plots, radar charts, bar graphs, and efficiency plots that showcased performance across key metrics. The preprocessing work ensured that comparisons were fair, contextualized, and aligned with Bournemouth's tactical identity under Andoni Iraola.

2 Wing Backs

Under Andoni Iraola, fullbacks are expected to perform high-volume defensive and offensive duties. Bournemouth deploys a system that demands both progressive ball carrying and aggressive pressing from its wingbacks, with overlapping and underlapping runs that support wide overloads and transitions.

With Bournemouth's current starting left back, Milos Kerkez, attracting significant interest from top European clubs, there is a strong possibility he could depart in the summer transfer window. As such, identifying a suitable replacement that fits the tactical and financial profile of the club became a key objective in this scouting initiative.

To narrow down potential replacements, we constructed a shortlist by filtering for fullbacks under the age of 24 (with the exception of Kepa) with balanced offensive and defensive output. The clustering process focused on key metrics that represent modern fullback demands:

- Progressive Passes (PrgP)
- Tackles Won per 90
- Interceptions
- Aerial Duels Won
- Tackle Success Percentage
- Crosses into the Box per 90
- Touches in Attacking Third

Players were standardized and clustered, and only those within the same statistical profile as Kerkez were selected. This method ensured consistency in tactical fit while allowing room to target under-the-radar prospects from other leagues.

The final list of targets included:

- **Jon Aramburu** (Real Sociedad)
- **Rayan Aït-Nouri** (Wolves)
- **Tyrick Mitchell** (Crystal Palace)
- **Vanderson** (AS Monaco)

To visualize this, radar charts were constructed comparing each shortlisted player to Kerkez using Bournemouth's tactical averages. These charts help illustrate the statistical similarities in attacking and defensive contribution:

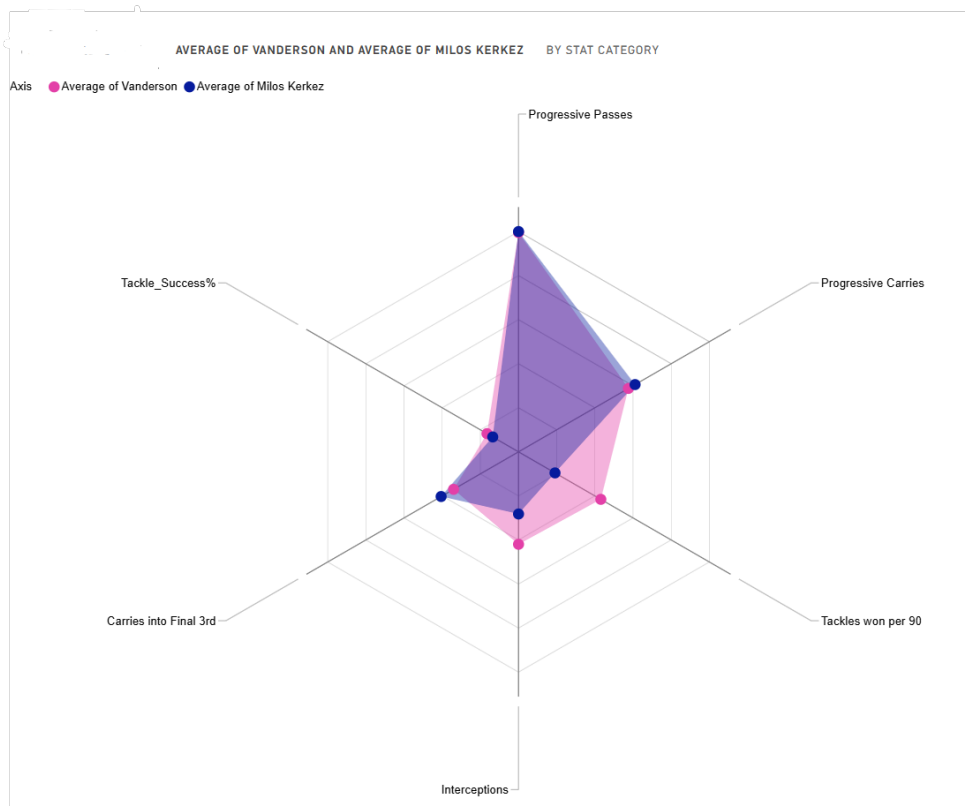

Figure 1: This radar chart compares Vanderson's average performance across six key fullback metrics with Bournemouth's current left-back, Milos Kerkez. Vanderson slightly trails Kerkez in progressive passes and carries into the final third, but exceeds him in interceptions and shows comparable numbers in progressive carries. His Tackle Success % is also competitive, indicating strong defensive fundamentals. The overall shape of the radar demonstrates a balanced profile that mirrors Kerkez's contributions on both ends of the pitch, reinforcing Vanderson's suitability as a like-for-like tactical replacement.

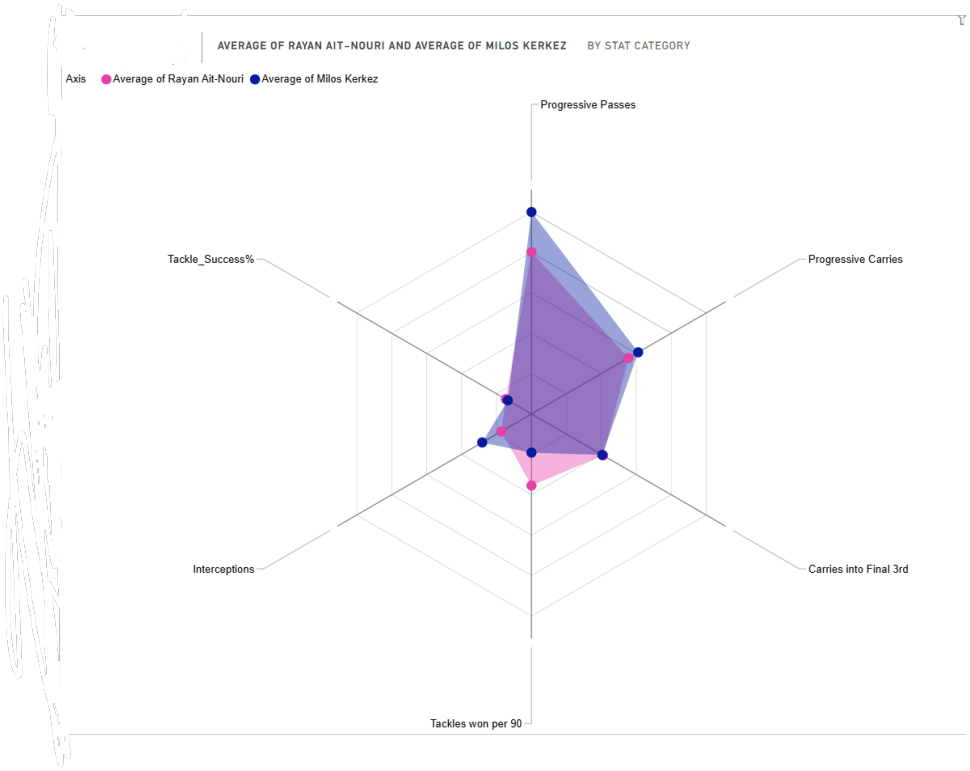

Figure 2: Aït-Nouri shows strong output in progressive carries and carries into the final third, closely matching Kerkez's profile in these attacking areas. While Kerkez slightly outperforms in progressive passing and interceptions, Aït-Nouri provides greater balance in tackling metrics. The radar shape indicates that Aït-Nouri would offer similar offensive thrust with additional defensive resilience, making him a tactically compatible alternative should Kerkez depart in the summer.

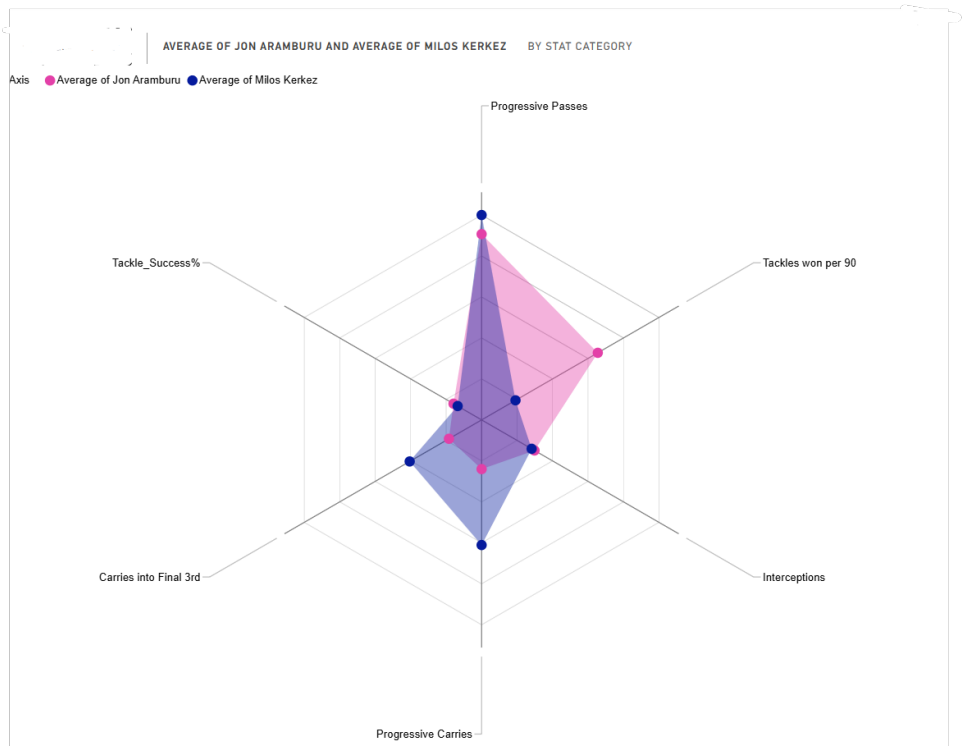

Figure 3: Aramburu outperforms Kerkez in defensive actions such as tackles won per 90 and tackle success percentage, suggesting a more defensively disciplined profile. On the other hand, Kerkez maintains an edge in progressive carries and attacking third involvement, aligning with his more advanced role under Iraola. While Aramburu may offer less attacking thrust, his defensive reliability and passing range make him an appealing fit for Iraola's pressing structure, especially in matches where a more conservative fullback is required.

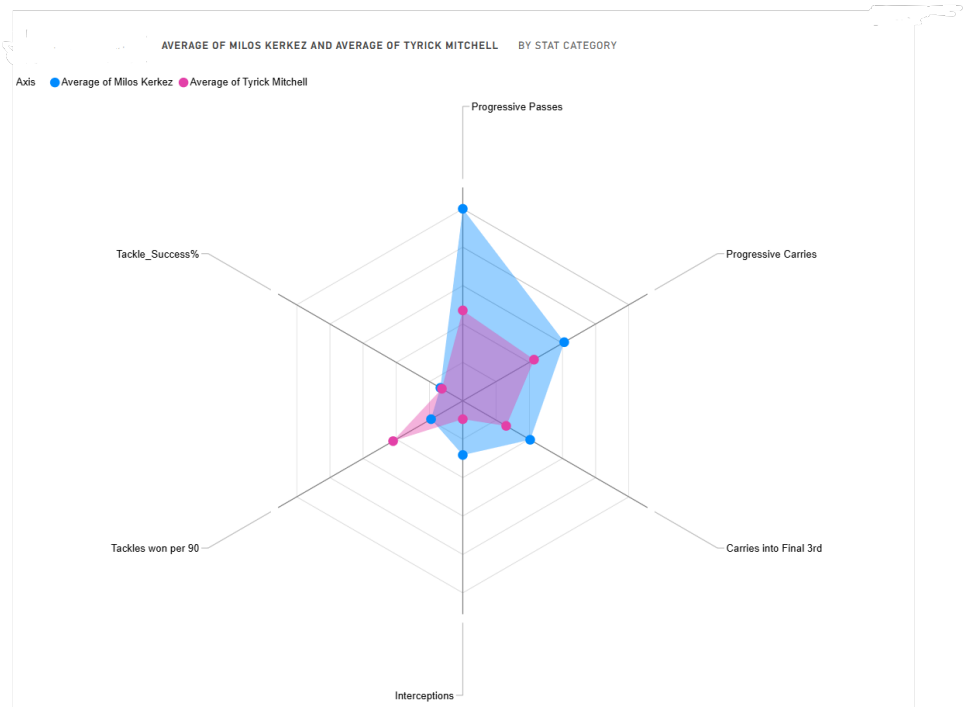

Figure 4: The radar chart compares Tyrick Mitchell with Milos Kerkez across both offensive and defensive metrics. While Mitchell slightly outperforms Kerkez in defensive categories such as tackle success rate and tackles won per 90, he lags behind significantly in progressive passing and carries into the final third. This suggests that Mitchell fits better in a more defensive fullback role, offering reliability in duels but limited contribution in possession. If Bournemouth opts for a more conservative shape or seeks defensive reinforcement at fullback, Mitchell represents a low-risk, system-compatible alternative.

To assess value for money, an **Efficiency Score** was calculated with the following formula:

$$EfficiencyScore = \frac{DefensiveScore + OffensiveScore}{Salary \times 52 \times MarketValue} \tag{1}$$

Where:

- Defensive Score = Tackles Won + Interceptions + Aerial Duels Won + Tackle Success %
- Offensive Score = PrgP + Crosses + Touches in Final Third

The Efficiency Score helped rank players based on performance relative to financial cost. The following horizontal bar chart illustrates the results:

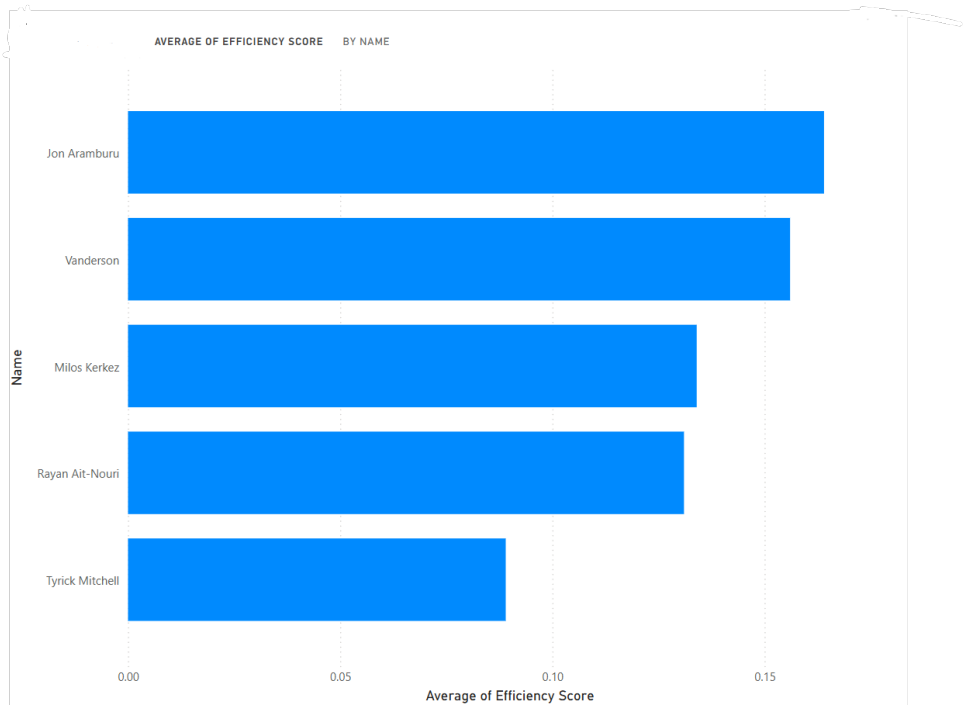

Figure 5: This horizontal bar chart compares the Efficiency Score of each fullback candidate, factoring in both performance and financial cost. Jon Aramburu ranks the highest in cost-efficiency, offering strong statistical output relative to his lower salary and market value. Vanderson and Kerkez follow closely, suggesting both performance and sustainability. Meanwhile, Mitchell shows the lowest efficiency, reinforcing the notion that while defensively solid, he offers less overall value across key metrics.

Centerbacks

We identified four centerbacks who align with Bournemouth's current defensive and tactical profile — specifically players who are active in duels, contribute to ball progression, and exhibit strong defensive decision-making. Each of the players below was chosen after filtering based on efficiency metrics, interception rates, and ability to operate in both low and high defensive blocks.

Shortlisted Players:

- **Facundo Medina** – A left-footed defender with excellent passing under pressure, Medina adds composure and build-up ability. His progressive passing and calmness in possession are standout qualities.
- **Bafodé Diakité** – Balanced defender with strong duel success and consistent defensive positioning. He offers aerial strength and versatility to play across the back line.

- **Matisma** – Young and efficient, Matisma shows great promise in interceptions and reading the game. His radar shows well-rounded coverage in core defensive metrics.
- **Ribeiro** – A high-effort, proactive defender who ranks strongly in tackles and pressures. His defensive activity rate per 90 is among the best in our shortlist.

Visualizations:

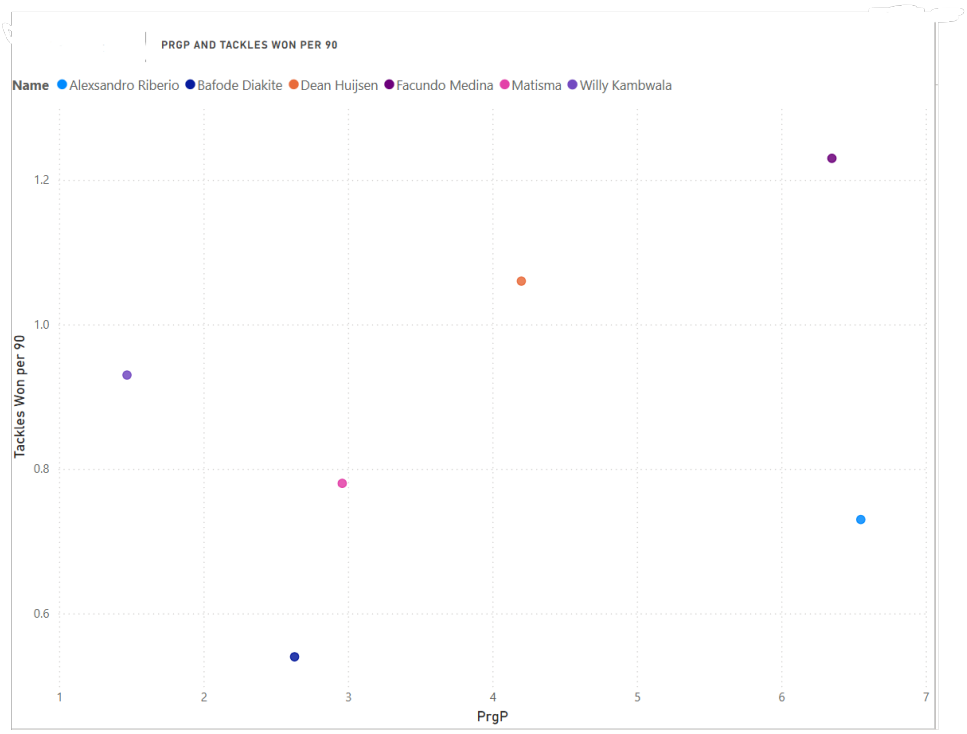

Figure 6: This scatter plot maps each center back's balance between progressive passing (x-axis) and defensive contributions via tackles won per 90 (y-axis). A higher value on both axes represents a player who excels both in initiating buildup and stopping attacks. Facundo Medina emerges as a standout with the highest combined values, highlighting his well-rounded profile. Dean Huijsen also shows a strong presence in both metrics, indicating his ability to contribute defensively while progressing the ball. Ribeiro and Kambwala offer above-average passing range or defensive grit but with room for growth in balance. This visualization helps identify players who can adapt to Bournemouth's aggressive defensive structure while aiding in possession transitions.

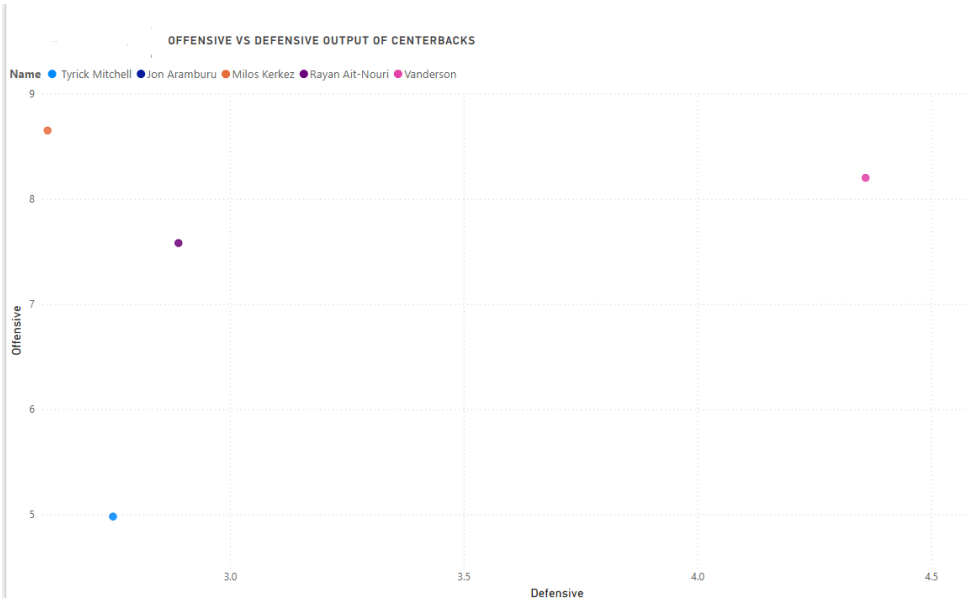

Figure 7: This scatter plot presents the balance between offensive and defensive tendencies for shortlisted fullbacks, based on composite scores. The x-axis represents defensive contributions, while the y-axis shows offensive involvement. Vanderson and Aït-Nouri are positioned in the upper right quadrant, indicating high values in both attacking and defensive metrics—ideal for Iraola's high-intensity system. Aramburu and Mitchell fall toward the defensive end, suggesting conservative profiles with less attacking contribution. Kerkez, Bournemouth's current starter, demonstrates a strong blend of both, providing a useful benchmark for potential replacements. This visualization aids in selecting a profile that complements the tactical demands placed on wingbacks in Bournemouth's setup.

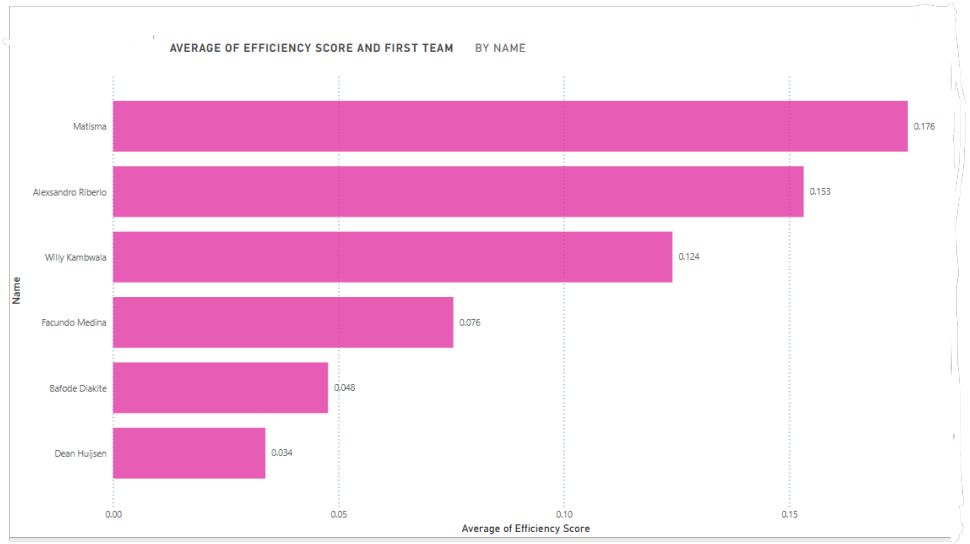

Figure 8: This horizontal bar chart compares the Efficiency Scores of the shortlisted center backs, calculated using their combined defensive and progressive output relative to their weekly salary and market value. Matisma leads the list with the highest efficiency score, indicating a strong statistical performance at a low cost. Alexsandro Ribeiro and Willy Kambwala follow closely, reinforcing their appeal as cost-effective options who match Bournemouth's tactical demands. Conversely, Dean Huijsen, despite his high-profile performances, ranks lowest due to a higher wage and market value, highlighting the trade-off between performance and affordability.

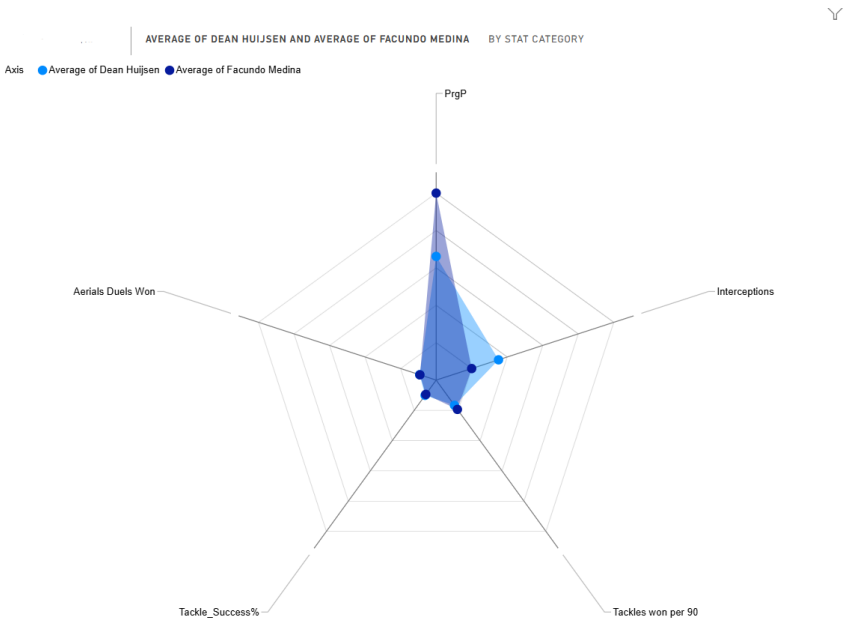

Figure 9: This radar chart compares Facundo Medina and Dean Huijsen across key defensive metrics: Progressive Passes (PrgP), Interceptions, Tackles Won per 90, Tackle Success %, and Aerial Duels Won. Medina clearly outperforms Huijsen in most categories, particularly in progressive passing and interceptions—attributes that align well with Iraola's need for proactive, ball-playing center backs. While Huijsen maintains a competitive aerial and tackling profile, Medina's ability to contribute in build-up and recover possession higher up the pitch makes him a strong candidate for replacing Senesi.

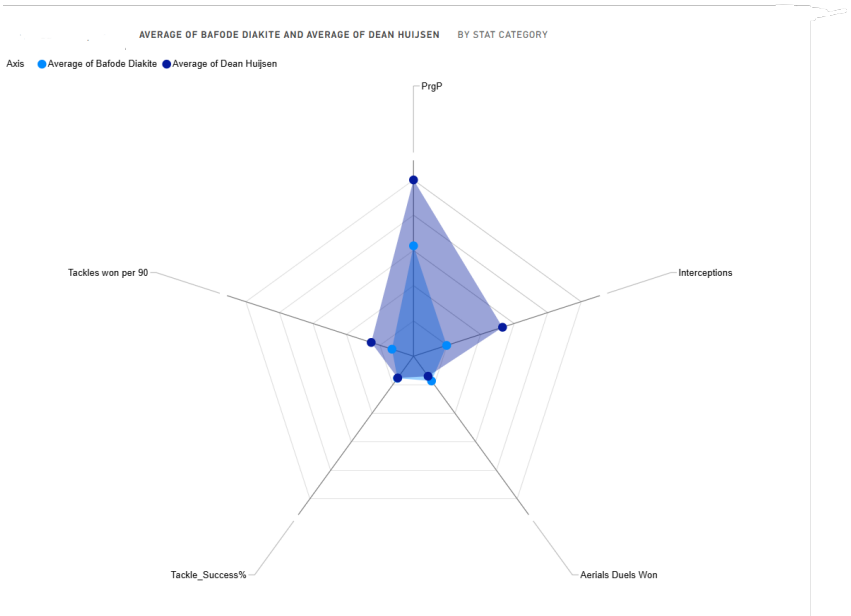

Figure 10: Diakité showcases a well-rounded profile with notable strength in interceptions and progressive passing (PrgP), indicating strong anticipation and ability to initiate attacks from deep. His aerial duel and tackle success metrics are comparable to Huijsen, highlighting his defensive consistency. Diakité's slightly more complete distribution across all attributes reflects a balanced, tactically flexible center back capable of playing in both back-three and back-four systems—an important trait for Iraola's rotation-heavy approach.

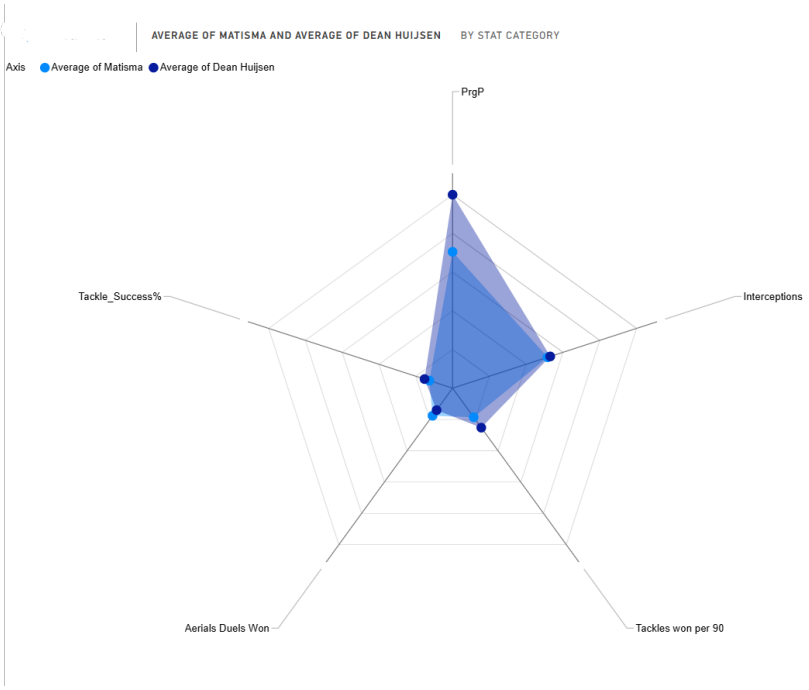

Figure 11: Matisma stands out in progressive passes (PrgP), demonstrating strong distribution skills critical for initiating build-up play under Iraola's system. While his aerial duels and tackle metrics are slightly behind Huijsen's, Matisma's output in interceptions and progressive metrics is promising. His overall profile suggests a mobile, technically confident defender who could develop into a reliable starter with further tactical coaching and minutes in a high-line system.

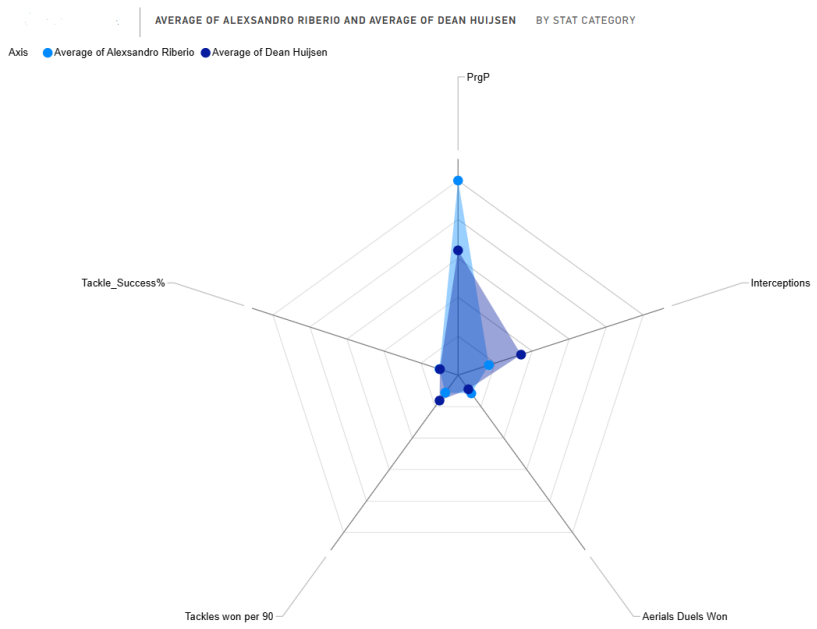

Figure 12: Ribeiro shows superior output in progressive passing (PrgP), suggesting a strong ability to contribute to Bournemouth's build-up phase from the back. He also holds competitive values in interceptions and aerial duels, although he lags slightly in tackle success percentage. Ribeiro's overall profile reflects a well-rounded, technically capable center back who offers immediate tactical fit and upside for a possession-oriented system.

Goalkeepers

For the goalkeeper position, we aimed to identify shot-stoppers who excel at both traditional goalkeeping metrics and modern data-driven indicators like post-shot expected goals (PSxG) and sweeping actions. We filtered goalkeepers playing in Europe's top leagues and compared their efficiency using per-90 metrics and radar profiles.

The three shortlisted candidates below were selected for their blend of reflex saves, consistency, and ability to fit into Bournemouth's style of playing out from the back.

Shortlisted Goalkeepers:

- **Anatoliy Trubin** – An elite-level shot-stopper who ranks among the top in PSxG overperformance. His sweeping ability and Champions League experience make him a high-upside option.
- **Andriy Lunin** – Exceptionally consistent in save percentage and known for strong positional awareness. Lunin brings both shot-stopping and good passing out of the back.

- **Kepa Arrizabalaga** – A high-profile keeper with strong distribution numbers and high defensive line experience. While slightly weaker on raw save data, he is trusted at the highest level.

Visualizations:

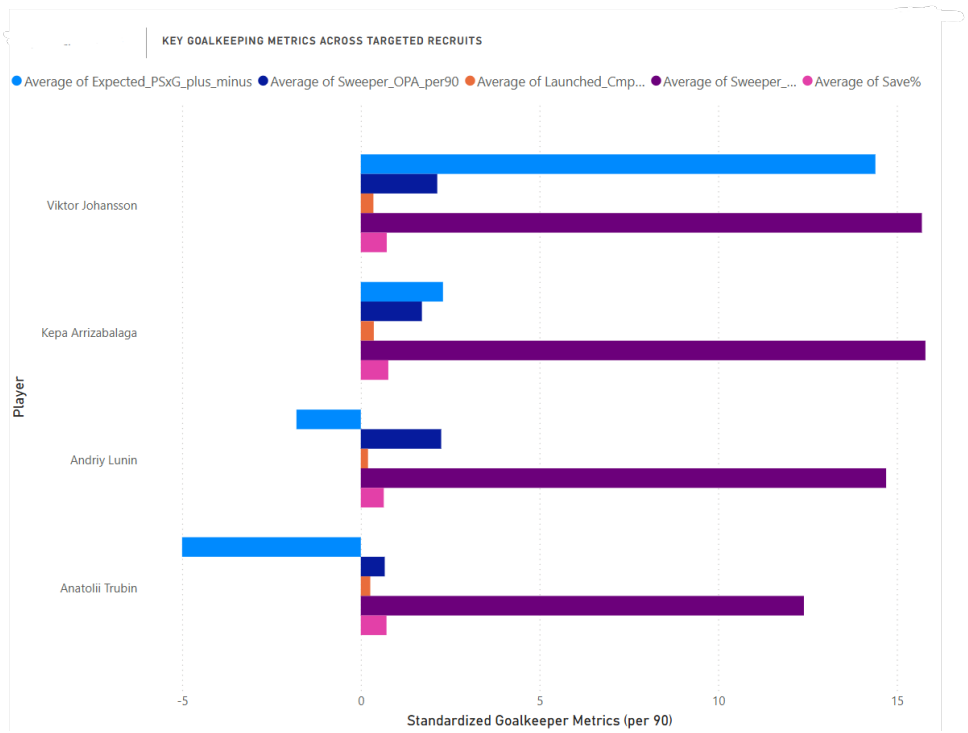

Figure 13: This bar chart illustrates key standardized goalkeeping metrics for the shortlisted targets: Trubin, Lunin, Kepa, and Johansson. The metrics include Expected PSxG Plus/Minus (blue), Sweeper OPA per 90 (dark blue), Launch Completion %, Average Defensive Distance, and Save Percentage (pink). Trubin stands out with excellent sweeping actions and high launch accuracy, but lower PSxG+/- values suggest variability in shot-stopping. Kepa and Johansson lead in save percentage and advanced sweeping actions, with Johansson showcasing the best PSxG+/- value among all options. These insights help compare goalkeeper suitability for Iraola's high defensive line and pressing system.

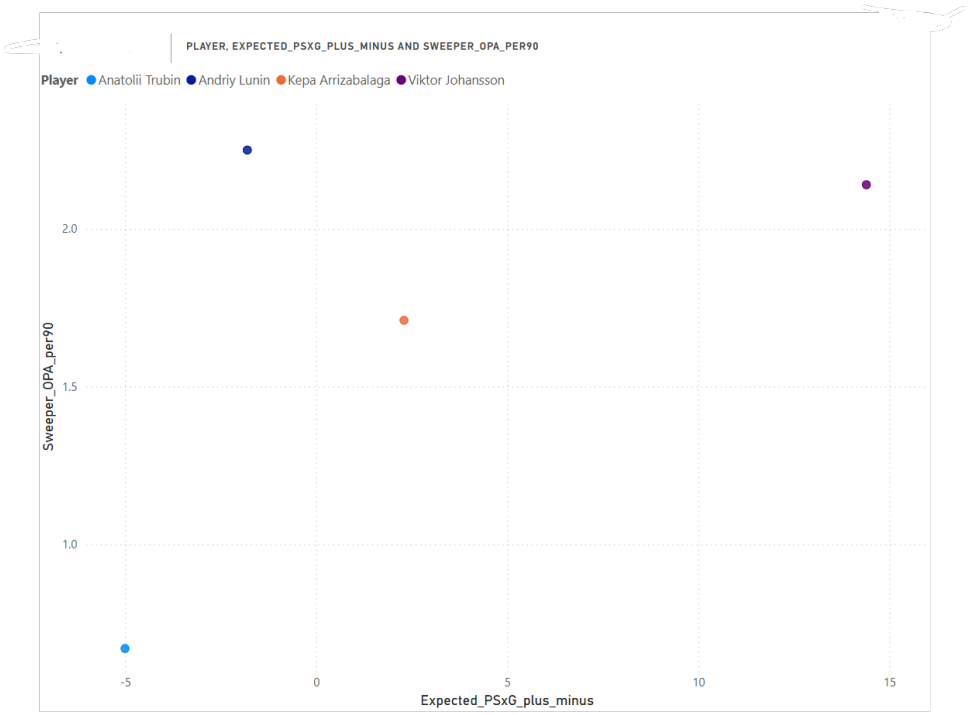

Figure 14: This scatter plot compares Expected PSxG Plus/Minus (x-axis) with Sweeper OPA per 90 (y-axis) to evaluate both shot-stopping performance and off-the-line activity for each goalkeeper. Higher values on the x-axis indicate goalkeepers who outperformed expected goals conceded, while higher values on the y-axis reflect more proactive sweeping behavior. Viktor Johansson emerges as a standout, combining excellent PSxG+/- with elite sweeping actions. In contrast, Trubin underperformed in PSxG+/- but may still be appealing tactically due to his Champions League experience and fit in a high line system.

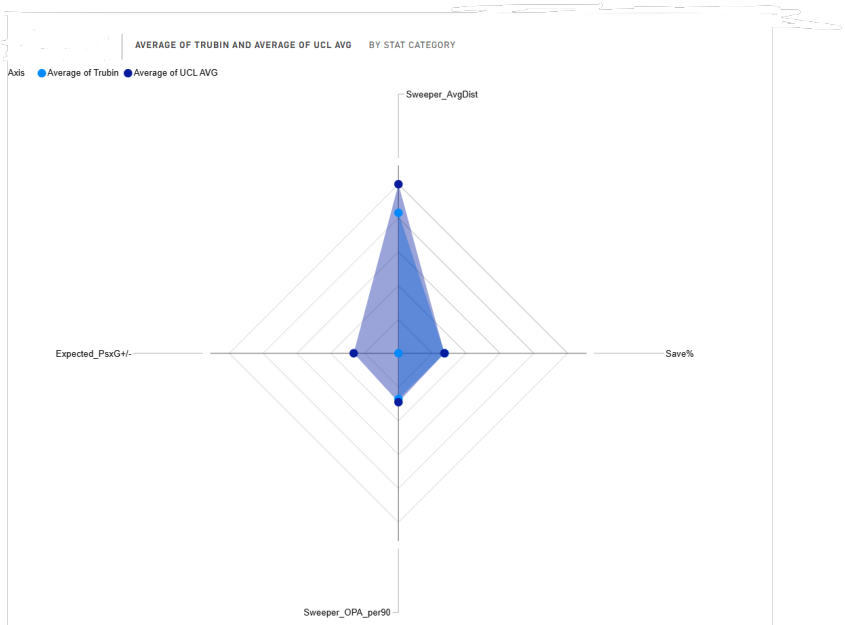

Figure 15: This radar chart compares Anatoliy Trubin's goalkeeping metrics to the average of UEFA Champions League goalkeepers. Trubin excels in Sweeper Actions per 90 and Sweeper Average Distance, confirming his comfort playing in a high line. His Expected PSxG+/- also outperforms the UCL average, indicating above-average shot-stopping ability. Although his save percentage is slightly below average, his aggressive positioning and sweeping profile make him an ideal tactical fit for Iraola's system at Bournemouth.

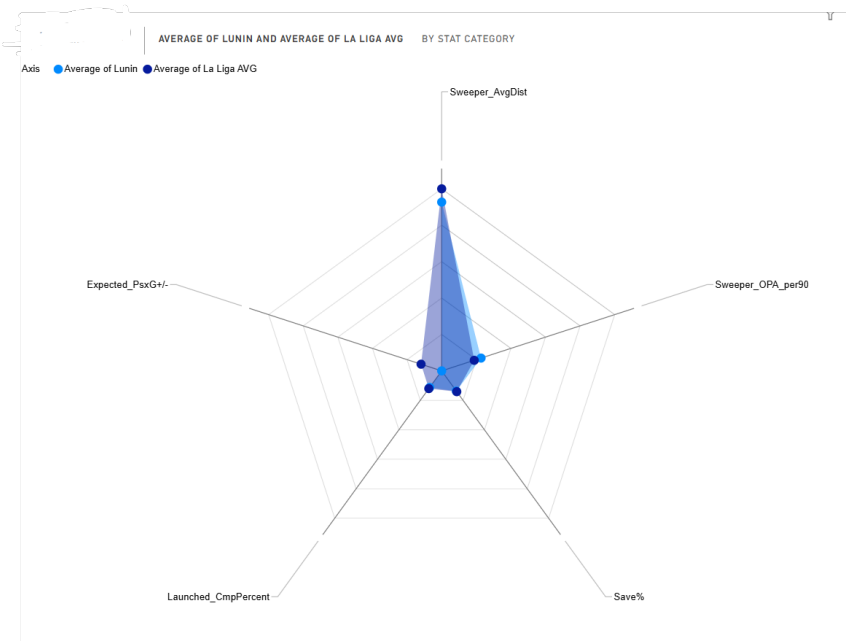

Figure 16: Andriy Lunin's radar chart showcases his above-average Sweeper Average Distance and Sweeper OPA/90, demonstrating his comfort operating in a high line—an essential trait in Iraola's pressing system. While his Save Percentage and Expected PSxG+/- are close to La Liga average, the chart reveals solid fundamentals and room for further growth. Lunin presents an appealing balance of upside and readiness, making him a viable long-term candidate if development continues.

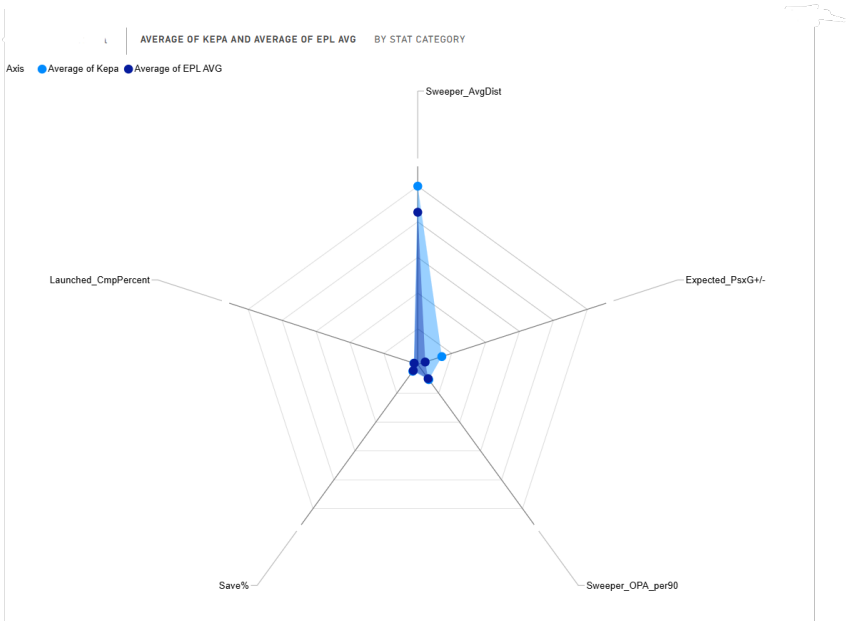

Figure 17: Kepa Arrizabalaga's radar chart compares his Premier League performance to the league average across key metrics. Kepa exhibits above-average Sweeper Average Distance, indicating his ability to operate in a high line, which is critical for Iraola's tactical setup. However, he performs at or slightly below average in Expected PSxG+/− and Save percentage, suggesting inconsistent shot-stopping performance. While he fits Bournemouth's tactical style well, his performance ceiling and cost must be evaluated if considered as a long-term solution.

Conclusion

This report presents a data-driven approach to player scouting tailored to AFC Bournemouth's tactical identity and positional needs. By integrating advanced performance metrics, clustering analysis, efficiency scoring, and visualization tools, we were able to identify a focused shortlist of players who not only perform well statistically, but also align with the team's playing philosophy.

For each position — goalkeeper, centerback, and wingback — we selected three to four players based on a balance of quantitative output and tactical fit. These players stood out for their consistency, efficiency, and the potential to contribute meaningfully within Bournemouth's existing system.

This framework demonstrates how analytics can enhance recruitment by surfacing undervalued players, confirming scout impressions, and providing objective comparisons across leagues. With further integration of salary data, age projections, and injury risk models, this process can scale into a broader recruitment strategy.

Our final recommendations are based not only on numbers, but on context, style, and

suitability — aiming to find the right player, not just the best player.